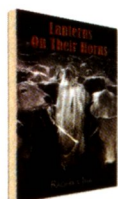


Till the Cows Come HOME

A parable for the social forces that are changing life in rural India

By Geeta Doctor



LANTERNS ON THEIR HORNS
by RADHIKA JHA
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 399
Pages: 472

Consider the cow. It's chewed its way through Indian culture with a persistence that has made it iconic. It's been a creature of myth, promising abundance, or dissonance when stolen from the gods or appropriated by external forces, used as a powerful image in modern political discourse, painted on the sides of trucks and also left to ruminate by the wayside,

a prey to the forces of progress that have rumbled past in indifference.

Radhika Jha has written a luminous fable that lifts the creature out of its habitual turpitude and places it on the fringes of the reader's imagination in a way that is quite often gripping without ever actually coming to grips with the situation. That of course, may be her intention, for as she suggests in a note at the beginning, the word "Gau" also means "the first ray of light, the eldest child of dawn. The nature of light is to move... Like its ancestor, the first ray of light, the nature of the cow is to move and therefore it had to go somewhere." Or as her narrative proves that somewhere could be nowhere.

Jha is best known for her highly assured first novel *Smell* set in Paris that is a coming-to-terms story of a young woman Leela, whose main weapon is a heightened sense of olfactory perception. Even in this story there are moments when Jha describes the intense odours that signal the impending birth of a calf, the smell of parched earth, the rot of flood waters,

or more characteristically when she describes the fears experienced by the small cow that walks through the narrative creating the somewhat rambling structure that holds it together.

Since Jha is nothing if not ambitious in her aims of creating a parable for social forces that are changing village India on the shoulders of two dysfunctional couples. Manoj Mishra is a history student from Jaipur who is inspired by a chance meeting with a Spanish woman tourist. She has a mission to import Spanish bulls to improve the Indian cattle stock. Mishra becomes the catalyst for such a venture when he finds himself marrying a rich Mumbai businessman's daughter Pratima and joins a centre for the artificial insemination of cows, where coincidentally he comes across a Spanish bull. Some of it is marginally funny. Jha is however too intense a writer to be able to pull it off either as comedy or satire. While she does manage to make Mishra's apprenticeship at the artificial insemination centre wholly riveting by her powerful descriptions of how to extract semen from a raging Spanish bull,

Mishra himself remains a hapless pawn in her hands, as does his even more dejected wife.

The second couple fare a little better, though they are equally mismatched. Ramu is a poor keeper of goats in the village of Nandgaon. He marries a beautiful educated wife named Laxmi who despises the fate that has befallen her after her farmer father's suicide until Ramu brings home a cow that has wandered into the nearby jungle.

It's a Paul Gallico tale that Jha has woven into a frothing *manthan* of intrigue with the cow as heroine. ■



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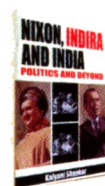
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